Politics FHS 2020-2021
Internal Examiners' Report

The administration of the politics examining went remarkably smoothly this year, thanks to the excellent administrative service from Durga Sapre, and the goodwill and hard work of numerous paper assessors. Among the large number of assessors for the question paper setting, and the initial and agreed marks stages we drew on ~15 post-doctoral postholders and doctoral students. We are very grateful for their participation in the process.

This year the classification rules reverted more nearly to normal – candidates were classified in the traditional way based on the mean score over 8 submitted papers. The time available to candidates between logging on to the on-line assessment platform and submission of the script, was also reduced (compared to 2020 open book exams), to 3.5 hours. Only a very few candidates had 'technical issues' with submitting scanned politics scripts. As will be reported by the PPE FHS examiners in almost all cases the penalty for late submission was waived, although we fear that candidates who spent too much time on writing and left insufficient for submission may have escaped penalty unjustly. (But the numbers, for politics at least, are very small).

Plagiarism and poor academic practice. Assessors spotted very few ostensibly significant cases. Unfortunately, the new assessment platform did not make it easy to routinely check Turnitin scores as Weblearn did in 2020. Because of the administrative time and effort that would have been involved in checking all scripts we were unable to do that. Given the number of candidates who in 2020 were found to have engaged in over-close paraphrase of sources in their essays, we recommend most strongly that from 2022, if on-line examining continues, the viewing functionality of Turnitin scores within Inspera should be improved.

The examiners checked the marks distribution for each paper, and the distribution for politics papers overall, against the median for the years 2017, 2018, and 2019. Interestingly, despite the very large number of candidate statements of mitigating circumstances there were no noticeable let alone statistically significant differences. One optional paper's marks distribution was noticeably higher than other papers'; on inspection this was revealed to be an assessor effect. The politics examiners agreed to reduce all marks for that paper by one point. This had the effect of bringing the marks distribution in line with other politics papers, and with the 2017-19 average, and did not penalise any candidates at the bottom of the 2.1 and 2.2 classes. We are very grateful to Musashi Harukawa who once again produced very clear and very helpful statistical analyses of marks distributions, including 'to order' in the course of our meetings. For future years Musashi's spreadsheet and algorithms will be adopted routinely by the examinations admin team; we thank him very much in advance for his assistance in that administrative project.

In a small number of cases scripts were sent to 3rd markers, either because of disagreement between the two initial assessors or, in the case of HPol scripts because at the pre-classification board stage it was found that a 3rd mark coming closer to one of the initial marks would have a significant effect on the candidate's classification for the degree. A number of politics assessors submitted 3rd marks that lay outside the range of the two initial marks. Our rules – both HP and PPE – do permit 3rd markers to do this in special circumstances, but the politics examiners on the HP board and other board members had some misgivings, and the marks were adjusted by the board to coincide with the higher or

lower of the initial two marks. For 2022 we recommend that the rules for both classification boards, and the instructions to politics assessors, be reviewed and clarified.

Elizabeth Frazer (Politics FHS 2020-21 convener)

Politics FHS 2021 - exam performance statistics by paper and school

	School	Takeup	Mean	St. Dev	Max	Min	>=70	>=60	>=50	>=40	Lower Q	Median	Upper Q
Total	PPE	796	66.5	4.49	80	45	27.00%	66%	6.41%	0.25%	64	67	70
	HP	160	67.3	6.13	80	26	36.20%	56.20%	5.00%	1%	65	68	70
	Combined	956	66.6	4.81	80	26	28.60%	64.60%	6.17%	0.42%	64	67	70
Advanced Paper in Theories of Justice	PPE	38	67.6	3.69	77	60	31.60%	68.40%	0%	0%	66	67.5	70
	HP	2	65.5	4.95	69	62	0%	100%	0%	0%	63.8	65.5	67.2
	Combined	40	67.5	3.68	77	60	31.70%	68.30%	0%	0%	66	68	70
British Politics and Government since 1900	PPE	79	65.2	5.66	80	51	21.50%	59.50%	19.00%	0.00%	61	65	69
	HP	15	61.9	11.9	70	26	13.30%	73.30%	0%	7%	63	64	69
	Combined	94	64.7	7.05	80	26	20%	61.70%	16.00%	1.06%	61	65	69
Comparative Demographic Systems	PPE	5	71.4	3.44	76	68	60%	40%	0%	0%	68	72	73
	HP	1	73	nan	73	73	100%	0%	0%	0%	73	73	73
	Combined	6	71.7	3.14	76	68	67%	33%	0%	0%	69	72.5	73
Comparative Government	PPE	52	66.1	3.72	75	57	23.10%	71.20%	5.77%	0%	64	66	68.2
	HP	12	66.7	3.14	72	61	16.70%	83.30%	0.00%	0%	65.5	66.5	68.2
	Combined	64	66.2	3.6	75	57	22%	73.40%	4.69%	0%	64	66	68.2
Comparative Political Economy	PPE	19	67.7	3.59	73	58	26.30%	68.40%	5%	0%	66.5	67	70
	HP	5	66.8	4.09	71	60	0.2	0.8	0	0	67	68	68
	Combined	24	67.5	3.62	73	58	25.00%	70.80%	4%	0%	66.8	67.5	69.5
Government and Politics of the United States	PPE	11	66.5	4.13	72	58	27.30%	63.60%	9.09%	0%	64.5	68	69
	HP	2	77	1.41	78	76	100.00%	0.00%	0%	0%	76.5	77	77.5
	Combined	13	68.2	5.46	78	58	38.50%	53.80%	7.69%	0%	65	68	71
International Relations (new regs)	PPE	122	66.3	4.07	77	49	25.40%	69.70%	4.10%	1%	64	66	69.8
	HP	27	67.3	3.93	75	57	33%	56%	11%	0%	66	68	70
	Combined	149	66.5	4.05	77	49	26.80%	67.10%	5.37%	1%	64	67	70
International Relations in the Era of Two World Wars	PPE	11	67.3	3.29	71	61	36.40%	63.60%	0%	0%	65.5	67	70.5
	HP	4	68.5	4.93	74	63	50%	50%	0%	0%	65.2	68.5	71.8
	Combined	15	67.6	3.64	74	61	40.00%	60.00%	0%	0%	65.5	67	71
International Relations in the Era of the Cold War	PPE	22	66.6	2.72	73	63	13.60%	86.40%	0.00%	0%	65	66	68
	HP	1	71	nan	71	71	100.00%	0.00%	0%	0%	71	71	71
	Combined	23	66.8	2.81	73	63	17.40%	82.60%	0.00%	0%	65	66	68
International Security and Conflict	PPE	41	68.2	3.78	76	59	46.30%	51.20%	2.44%	0%	66	68	71
	HP	9	69	3.35	73	62	55.60%	44.40%	0%	0%	68	70	71
	Combined	50	68.4	3.69	76	59	48.00%	50%	2.00%	0%	66	68.5	71
Marx and Marxism	PPE	19	68.7	3.09	74	63	42.10%	57.90%	0%	0%	67	69	70
	HP	0											
	Combined	19	68.7	3.09	74	63	42.10%	57.90%	0%	0%	67	69	70
Modern British Government and Politics	PPE	21	67	3.46	72	61	28.60%	71.40%	0.00%	0%	64	67	70
	HP	3	71	2.65	73	68	67%	33%	0%	0%	70	72	72.5
	Combined	24	67.5	3.58	73	61	33.30%	66.70%	0.00%	0%	64.8	68	70.2
Political Sociology	PPE	75	65.1	4.41	78	54	17.30%	70.70%	12.00%	0.00%	62	65	68
	HP	11	67.2	3.22	73	63	27%	73%	0%	0%	65.5	66	69
	Combined	86	65.4	4.32	78	54	18.60%	70.90%	10.50%	0.00%	62.2	66	68

no candidates in the bands 30-40 and <30, except BPG where combined 1% <30

Politics FHS 2021 - exam performance statistics by paper and school

	School	Takeup	Mean	St. Dev	Max	Min	>=70	>=60	>=50	>=40	Lower Q	Median	Upper Q
Political Thought: Bentham to Weber	PPE	13	67.5	4.01	76	61	23.10%	76.90%	0%	0%	66	67	69
	HP	0											
	Combined	13	67.5	4.01	76	61	23.10%	76.90%	0%	0%	66	67	69
Political Thought: Plato to Rousseau	PPE	14	65.6	4.72	71	55	14.30%	71.40%	14.30%	0%	64	67	69
	HP	6	69.2	3.6	75	64	50.00%	50.00%	0%	0%	68	69	70
	Combined	20	66.7	4.64	75	55	25%	65.00%	10.00%	0%	64	68	69.2
Politics in China	PPE	16	65.3	5.41	73	52	31.20%	62.50%	6.25%	0%	63.8	64.5	70.2
	HP	9	64.9	6.47	72	55	44%	22%	33%	0%	58	68	70
	Combined	25	65.2	5.68	73	52	36.00%	48.00%	16.00%	0%	63	65	70
Politics in Europe	PPE	3	68.7	4.04	73	65	33.30%	66.70%	0%	0%	66.5	68	70.5
	HP	1	70	nan	70	70	100%	0%	0%	0%	70	70	70
	Combined	4	69	3.37	73	65	50%	50%	0%	0%	67.2	69	70.8
Politics in Latin America	PPE	13	66.1	4.05	73	60	23.10%	76.90%	0.00%	0%	63	66	68
	HP	1	77	nan	77	77	1	0	0	0	77	77	77
	Combined	14	66.9	4.87	77	60	28.60%	71.40%	0.00%	0%	63	66.5	69.5
Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet Union	PPE	9	67.2	2.64	72	63	22.20%	77.80%	0%	0%	66	67	68
	HP	2	71.5	2.12	73	70	100%	0%	0%	0%	70.8	71.5	72.2
	Combined	11	68	3	73	63	36.40%	63.60%	0%	0%	66.5	67	70
Politics in South Asia (new regs)	PPE	3	68.7	3.79	73	66	33.30%	66.70%	0%	0%	66.5	67	70
	HP	0											
	Combined	3	68.7	3.79	73	66	33%	67%	0%	0%	66.5	67	70
Politics in South Asia (old regs)	PPE	0											
	HP	3	72	3.61	75	68	0.667	0.333	0	0	70.5	73	74
	Combined	3	72	3.61	75	68	67%	33%	0%	0%	70.5	73	74
Politics in Sub-Saharan Africa	PPE	14	68.1	3.11	73	61	28.60%	71.40%	0.00%	0%	67	68	69.8
	HP	4	69	3.37	73	65	50%	50%	0%	0%	67.2	69	70.8
	Combined	18	68.3	3.09	73	61	33.30%	66.70%	0.00%	0%	67	68	70
Politics in the Middle East	PPE	23	65.7	4.12	72	55	22%	70%	9%	0%	64.5	65	67.5
	HP	9	70	3.77	76	65	44%	56%	0%	0%	67	69	72
	Combined	32	66.9	4.43	76	55	28.10%	65.60%	6.25%	0%	65	66.5	70
Social Policy	PPE	26	65.2	4.87	76	58	19.20%	69.20%	11.50%	0%	62.2	65	68
	HP	0											
	Combined	26	65.2	4.87	76	58	19%	69%	12%	0%	62.2	65	68
Sociological Theory	PPE	13	65.6	5.14	75	55	23%	69%	8%	0%	63	65	68
	HP	3	60.3	11.9	70	47	33.30%	33.30%	0.00%	33%	55.5	64	67
	Combined	16	64.6	6.68	75	47	25.00%	62.50%	6.25%	6%	63	65	68.5
The Politics of the European Union	PPE	12	67.9	5.26	75	61	41.70%	58.30%	0%	0%	64	66.5	74
	HP	2	68	0	68	68	0.00%	100.00%	0.00%	0%	68	68	68
	Combined	14	67.9	4.84	75	61	36%	64%	0%	0%	64.2	67.5	73
Theory of Politics	PPE	95	66.5	4.54	77	53	30%	64%	6%	0%	64	66	70
	HP	19	65.8	6.29	77	51	21.10%	68.40%	10.50%	0%	63.5	67	69
	Combined	114	66.4	4.85	77	51	28.10%	64.90%	7.02%	0%	64	66.5	70
Thesis in Politics	PPE	20	68.5	6.35	78	58	50%	45%	5%	0%	62.8	69.5	73.5
	HP	6	69	1.73	70	66	50.00%	33.30%	0%	0%	69	70	70
	Combined	26	68.6	5.7	78	58	50%	42%	4%	0%	65	70	71

no candidates in the bands 30-40 and <30

Thesis in Politics

26 students submitted Politics thesis in Trinity 2021.
Thesis titles are listed below.

- The impact of Jewish Anti-British Violence on the press coverage of Mandate Palestine 1946-47
- Gender-driven democratization? Evaluating the role of women in the Tunisian Ennahda Party's moderation and cooperativeness.
- Political dissent in Romania 1970-1989: The Role of Intellectuals
- On opposition agency: explaining patterns of opposition party mobilisation in competitive authoritarian regimes
- Adorno on Fascism via the Culture Industry
- An Egalitarian Justification for Online Public Shaming of Public Figures
- A consumer-centred approach to challenging platform power
- Can the neutral liberal state respect religious believers? Accommodationist liberalism and the ethics of care
- Are different Middle Eastern nation's attitudes and policies towards veiling mainly the product of religious doctrine and belief?
- Religion and Nationalism: Exploring how religious denomination explains preferences towards nationalism in the context of Scotland.
- Walking the Tightrope: China, Israel and Palestine, an Increasingly Precarious Balancing Act?
- 'Diversity of thought': Is diversity in the UK Cabinet necessary or achievable?
- National Identity and Voting Behaviour at Welsh Elections
- Autopilot: How and why states respond to automation
- Vox Populi, Vox Stanley: What Drove the Prime Minister's
- To what extent does a state's refugee policy enhance or constrain its sovereignty: The Case of Tanzania 2015-2020
- how had the CCP's United Front influenced popular support for the CCP in Hong Kong through localist citizenship from November 2013 to the end of 2019?
- Thinking Outside the Black Box: Rethinking Power and Agency in the Relationship between Users and Facebook's Algorithm
- Wielding a double-edged sword: how the Chinese Communist Party has incorporated nationalism to sustain its regime legitimacy from 2012 to 2019
- 'The Effect of Closed Party Lists on Legislative Party Cohesion: The Case of New Zealand'
- What is wrong with cultural assimilation?
- How has the role and nature of constitutional conventions in the British state changed in response to modern constitutional reforms?
- 'The Self' in Philosophe Thought
- In the race to control the next-generation technologies, is the global tech industry breaking up due to a systemic rivalry between China and the West?
- Platonic Justice as a Social Virtue: The Importance of Brotherhood in Plato's Republic
- Rage Within the Machine: Ideologies of anti-racism in the post-Obama era

201 Comparative Government

No questions were reported during the exam and the overall quality of answers was commendable.

The unweighted average score across all questions was similar.

I now turn to general impressions from examiners on relevant questions. The commentary of a question here (or lack thereof) has no bearing on whether the topic will appear on the next iteration of the exam.

Question 1. Strong answers defined "civil society" and presented a threshold or definition of successful democratization. Answers needed to define democratization and defend this definition. Mediocre answers ignored the civil-society component and focused on alternative explanations of democratization. Creative and high-quality answers focused on the mechanisms for why civil society would matter for democratization, or why civil society might epiphenomenal to regime type.

Question 3. Strong answers defined "rigid" in terms of capability of amendment and gave examples from specific countries. Exams needed to justify which dependent variables constitutional rigidity would matter (referencing Tsebelis et al., for instance). Strong answers also engaged the issue of whether constitutional rigidity competed with other explanations for outcomes

Question 4. Answers should have presented competing outcomes relevant for political party "behaviour" and defended selection of a subset of such outcomes (such as party cohesion). The best exams presented a mix of quantitative and qualitative evidence from multiple regions (such as Europe, the US, the Latin America), citing Shugart, Samuels. More sophisticated answers posited arguments for conditions under which parties might behave differently.

Question 5. Answers defined the key outcomes of interest regarding party change, and considered the relevance of party stability as well. Good answers discussed the role of electoral systems, conditions for new party entry, and structural conditions for such change.

Question 6. Answers should have provided definitions of different electoral systems and provided relevant examples of change. Answers could discuss the origins of electoral systems but needed to link these origins to the argument about change. Good answers provided detail on the mechanisms of why certain variables, such as party systems or structural causes, would facilitate change in the mechanics of rules affecting the translation of votes to seats. Relevant references included discussion of Bol, et al. Benoit, and Katz from the list.

Question 8. Answers should have discussed aspects of growth and defended them. Answers could draw on the readings by Acemoglu, Sen, Glaeser, Ross.

Question 9. Subtle answers defined benefits and costs of federalism, engaging in both arguments about economic growth, fiscal outcomes, and ethnic or civil conflict. They also provided a framework for defining when benefits would outweigh costs. Good essays need not have talked about all these categories, but should have shown awareness that multiple categories were possible. Relevant discussion could include engaging with Baake, Bermeo,

Bunce, Beramendi, Rodden, Wibbels. Strong answers showed conceptual understanding of how federalism is defined and used case-specific as well as cross-national evidence.

Question 11. Good answers defined the conditions under which legislatures matter in terms of affecting outcomes. The prompt is a strong statement, and so rejection of the statement is more straightforward; better essays distinguished by posing a clear argument about why legislatures would be relevant. Relevant works to engage include mainly Gandhi, Levitsky and Way, Svolik,

Question 12. Answers need to define the terms in the prompt, referencing Olson. More subtle answers provided conditions for the prompt and incorporated evidence from Europe and outside of Europe. Acceptable and commendable answers challenged the assumption that only such bandits do become state builders.

202 British Politics and Government since 1900

There were 94 candidates of whom 79 were in PPE and 15 were in HP. The pattern of answers between the two subjects was very similar.

Q1. How successfully had the Liberal Party adjusted to democratic pressures by 1914?
(23 answers)
Candidates knew a great deal about Liberals, occasionally interpreted as only New Liberalism. The words 'democratic pressures' were open to a wide area of examination, and answers demonstrated this, applying the term to trade unions, the franchise and responsibility of government to people. Some pointed out that Liberals promoted democratic change and did not only adjust to it, and that this was only a stage in the development of Liberals and Liberalism. Only a few answers argued that the party had failed to adjust to change, usually supporting this with alleged decline in the party in specific geographical areas. On the whole a well-answered question.

Q2. Why did it take until 1914 to enact Irish Home Rule?
(5 answers)
Most of the (few) answers were a little too partisan and picked on a 'villain': the House of Lords, Ulster Protestants, the foolish tactics of the Conservative or Liberal Parties. Opposition in England was also mentioned but disappointingly few knew much about Ireland itself beyond Ulster and a Catholic/Protestant division. A couple of candidates challenged the question and pointed out that Home Rule may have been enacted in 1914 but the future of Ireland was still causing extreme violence by 1919-21, and the final decisions about what sort of self-government were taken by the Lloyd George coalition.

Q3. How much of the achievement of votes for some women in 1918 can be credited to militant suffragism?
(39 answers)
A much answered question. Candidates wrote well-informed essays although there was a fairly heavy reliance on a small number of authors. This gave the impression of standard tutorial essays being reproduced, and a lack of knowledge about the significance of 1914-18. Although answers displayed a good deal about militant suffragism itself, they often showed less about its place in the suffrage movement as a whole. A few answers explored the issue of class and suffragism and ventured into the question of which groups of women were actually enfranchised 1918. Answers usually concluded that militancy helped suffragism by maintaining the issue at the forefront of politics but mostly hindered it by alienating hitherto friendly opinion.

Q4. 'War, not politics, was the engine of state expansion in the period 1900 - 1918.' Do you agree?
(8 answers)
A small number of answers, and most of them weak. Candidates tended to know about 1900-1914 or about the war. Comments about state expansion were often vague and drawn from other subjects such as party change. It was also unwise of some students to try a chronological approach to problems such as bureaucratic change, or ideology or growth in government expenditure. Only a couple of answers were based on the question; what governments controlled, wanted and were forced to do in peace and war.

Q5. What were the main sources of the Labour Party's growth before 1924?
(23 answers)
Of the candidates who wrote on this question, several did so with knowledge and panache. Nearly everyone also realized that starting in 1900 and trying to plough methodologically through to the end was impossible. Only a few adopted an 'inevitablist' view; difficult to do persuasively but achieved very well here. More considered trade unions, socialism and the effects of war. Some were also interesting on the recruitment of Liberals and the inheritance of parts of Liberalism by Labour. Almost all possible approaches were on display and there were a few excellent essays.

Q6. Is Conservative electoral success in EITHER the 1930s OR the 1950s best explained in terms of 'One Nation Conservatism'?
(1 answer; 7 answers)
There was only 1 taker for the 1930s and 7 for the 1950s of whom some were wobbly about the meaning of the term One Nation Conservatism. Candidates sometimes got the dates of elections wrong (and sometimes Prime Ministers) which made of some of their claim for subsequent developments implausible. One answer was mainly on decolonisation, on which there was no question. A few pointed out that Conservative Electoral success was built on fragile bases but were weak explaining why.

Q7. Did the Attlee Governments do more to promote socialism or to reinvigorate capitalism?
(50 answers)
Answers ranged from the clever, thoughtful and argumentative to the reproduced tutorial essay whose title did not coincide with the question asked here. A few candidates assumed that 'promote socialism or … reinvigorate capitalism' were opposites of each other. Therefore, conclusion of essays sometimes simply plumped for one exclusively (usually capitalism). More subtle consideration of the state of the economy in 1945 and the options which opened and closed led to clever answers to which there was no predictable conclusion. A surprising number of essays told the reader that Britain was in a parlous financial condition in 1945 yet managed fast expenditure, without, apparently any obvious source. Those who did mention Marshall Aid then had an easy route to discussing the American alliance and how this constrained the Government (reinvigorating capitalism). Good answers displayed an impressive knowledge of literature and sometimes contested the received wisdom of virtually all authors (including nationalisation having little to do with socialism).

Q8. When, if ever, did social class cease to be the dominant force in British electoral politics?
No answers

Q9. Why was it a Conservative Government that took Britain into the European Economic Community?
Only 4 answers.

Q10. In what sense, if any, was the work of the Thatcher Governments ideologically driven?
(63 answers)
The most popular question and unsurprisingly spanning answers from the excellent to the very weak. There were a few basic and recurrent faults. One was to spend too much time deciding what ideology was being examined, if any – to the almost total exclusion of the work of the governments. Another was failure to disentangle ideology – Thatcherism – from Thatcher herself (being a grocer's daughter and coming from Grantham does not constitute an ideology). In several scripts, no-one other than Thatcher was mentioned at all and in others the role of prominent people was unclear. Howe and Lawson as Chancellors had something to do with tax rates, others with privatisation. Good answers considered how far the intentions of the governments changed between 1979 and 1990 and what, in Conservative eyes had succeeded and what had failed. The case for late twentieth-century Conservatism being different from earlier Conservatism was well made in some scripts (and equally well argued in the opposite direction in others). Many candidates argued to sensible conclusions demonstrating knowledge of material they required. But a few began their essays by stating their conclusion, writing the 'Thatcher essay' they intended to write whatever they were asked and in their final paragraph returned to their largely irrelevant introduction and wrote it again. But the best essays were fluent, convincing, and impressive.

Q11. Did New Labour find a 'Third Way'?
(57 answers)
Answers were well informed about what the Third Way was intended to be and also whether it could be programmatic. Several answers were also sceptical about the use of the term as an analytical tool, but nevertheless concluded that Labour did find a Third Way. Disappointingly, large numbers of candidates seemed weak on Labour legislation to support their arguments. Even larger numbers wrote nothing whatsoever about Gordon Brown's premiership – a serious omission. Instead candidates got tangled in trying to show that Blair was not a socialist and Labour must therefore have found a Third Way. The title of the question allowed candidates wide leeway in what they wanted to argue, and the best answers were original and diverse.

Q12. Why did the Conservatives and Liberal Democrats govern as a coalition from 2010 to 2015?
Only 3 answers.

203 Theory of Politics

1. Is violence a form of power, or something fundamentally different from power?
This question attracted some good candidates who offered careful and well-referenced answers; most tended to stick to a 'on the one hand, on the other hand' form of essay rather than engaging with the conceptual difficulties and challenges of holding the two apart or running them together.

2. In what sense, if at all, does freedom require meaningful self-governance?
This was a popular question. As ever, many candidates relied on some form of the positive v negative distinction without engaging with the concept 'meaningful self-governance'. More successful candidates gave this concept a run for its money with the best distinguishing between the quality of the option set facing an individual or group, and the authenticity of the group's or individual's relationship with 'self'. Very few distinguished clearly between responses to this problem at the level of the collective (nation, community, corporation etc) and of the individual citizen, subject, or agent.

3. 'The state's superiority to even the most favoured form of anarchy is necessary but not sufficient for its legitimacy.'
It was difficult to disentangle the various clauses in this question and many overlooked some or even many of them. As ever, the default was to a prepared essay topic: how can state authority be legitimated? The best essays considered diverse ways in which a state might be considered to be 'superior' to anarchy, before moving on to the question of where such superiority fits into a set of necessary and/or sufficient conditions for legitimacy. Rather few candidates managed to set out the salient differences between a state and a 'most favoured anarchy' such that one could be considered to be superior to the other.

4. Does the idea that gender is socially constructed help or hinder the pursuit of feminist goals?
This very popular question was a real challenge. It takes accuracy to specify how 'gender being socially constructed' might hinder feminist goals – a number of candidates reached for the care ethics, or the 'different but equal' literatures without managing exactly to clarify how they contrast with the idea that 'gender being socially constructed' is consistent with gender being transformed. How gender, or any other social construct, might be transformed, and exactly what 'feminist goals' with respect to its transformation can be said to be, were not often mentioned. Candidates often seemed to lack concrete understanding of the history of feminism as a movement or as an ideology. The best essays addressed more of these problems.

5. If egalitarians ought to be concerned with valuable social relationships, should they be committed to distributing them equally?
Many candidates were clearly keen to write on egalitarianism. Most struggled with the question, however, as it requires in quite sophisticated comparison between relational and distributive egalitarianism, and, in particular, thuoght and reasoning about the conditions for (the predominance of) valuable social relationships in a society, in contrast to the idea of distributing valuable social relationships in the way that we can think of distributing money or other material goods. A striking number of candidates seemed to think that distributing them is the way to go. The more successful essays saw that concern with valuable social relationships might be an ethical and a political focus, and were able to ask what an egalitarian society would look like with respect to these. Rather few addressed head on the question what makes a social relationship 'valuable', or to whom.

6. Does the pursuit of racial justice require political action beyond the reform of the 'basic structure' of society?
The best answers here engaged thoughtfully with the notion of 'basic structure', the degree to which any reform of it as is would achieve racial justice, and if it would not what further political action would be called for or effective. Some candidates had recourse to good levels of knowledge of named philosophers and debates about what is included in the basic structure concept; others incorporated thinking about the structural (in)justice literature, how racial justice might be achieved, and what it might look like.

7. 'There are principles of distributive justice that apply globally, but these are different from the principles that apply within the state.' Discuss.
Many candidates offered acceptable surveys of the global justice debates. Good essays considered what principles of justice apply within states and asked whether they do or do not apply globally; the best considered whether there are principles of justice that might or do apply globally but do not apply within the state and why.

8. Do rights necessarily protect interests?
Rather few takers for this question. Perhaps candidates simply did not feel confident enough with the 'interest theory of rights' – from ones who knew what that meant we received some good full well organised essays. The very best candidates took into account the 'necessarily' in the question: a good way of tackling that would be to ask whether there are any rights that indisputably are rights, that do not protect interests. Of course, that raises the question 'whose interests?'

9. What role, if any, should 'epistemic benefits' play in efforts to justify democracy?
Some candidates were rather vague about what an 'epistemic benefit' might be; others plunged straight into Condorcet's theorem, or the benefits of democratic public discussion, without pausing to consider how these are or are not 'epistemic'. There was similar speed in moves between democracy and epistocracy. Some candidates offered full well organised essays on the significance of knowledge, the distribution of knowledge, truth, and scientific validity, in justifications of democracy.

10. Are cultural and religious exemptions from some state laws compatible with equality?
Some candidates were well prepared, and offered well organised fairly full essays. The fundamental question whether equality demands uniformity of treatment – reward and punishment – or demands individually and particularly focussed diversity of treatment, and how these different versions of egalitarianism are relevant to the demands of state law, were more implied than addressed by candidates. It was striking, also, that candidates were relatively reluctant to consider concrete examples of exemptions familiar from their own political and legal systems.

11. Is it ever legitimate for states to punish individuals for committing victimless crimes?
Very few students answered this question, and they interpreted it in wildly different ways.

12. How far do conservative and socialist criticisms of the market economy overlap?
Disappointingly few takers, given the importance of this question both historically and in contemporary politics and public policy.

204 Modern British Government and Politics

There was a somewhat narrow spread of the questions attempted – with two questions receiving no answers (Qs 1 and 7) while the electoral topic (Q 13) was answered by more than half of candidates. This is potentially a concern about the paper to the extent it reflects a narrower range of topics being taught than the course contains.

The markers also noted the old-fashioned style of a single country paper, which is vulnerable to using a limited literature which constrains the candidates' answers. Consideration will be given to how candidates can be encouraged to use more comparative perspectives going forward. There was considerable variation in quality of answers, both across scripts and within some scripts - though no question was answered overwhelmingly well or poorly.

1. Are attempts to clarify constitutional rules and conventions, such as the Cabinet Manual, too dominated by the views of the executive? (0 answers)

No answers.

2. Can the UK Parliament only exercise power over the executive during a hung parliament? (9 answers)

Answers to this question were good overall. Better answers showed understanding of the Wright reforms, and displayed a detailed knowledge of procedure and structures within Parliament incorporating key literature (e.g. Russell and Gover). There were discussions of the role of the House of Lords, the backbench business committee and select committees. Particularly good answers also combined this with accounts of changes in backbench behaviour, sometimes incorporating models of legislator behaviour such as the intra- versus inter- party mode (King). Weaker answers tended to exclude detailed consideration of the Lords for no good reason, over-generalise from specific periods such as the 2010-15 Coalition or Theresa May's minority government, or provide a summary of literature without much analysis.

3. Has the power of the Prime Minister in British politics increased since 1997? If so, how might its influence be constrained? (11 answers)

Answers to this question were very good overall, with a significant percentage of excellent answers, though still with substantial variation. Good answers addressed both halves of the question, or gave a clear 'no' to the first part negating the need for an answer to the second. The core executive model and the 'presidentialisation' debate were often used to provide structure for the argument, though some also ranged more widely (e.g using Skowronek and the political time model). Most answers attempted discussions of prerogative and agenda powers and their limits versus PMs political and personal authority. Weaker answers tended to misunderstand the Core Executive model, seeing it as a type of government rather than a theory of power, or conceptualised presidentialisation unclearly. Some were over-reliant on Heffernan (2003) and the Blair-Brown era with not much coverage of later developments.

4. What would be the advantages and disadvantages of a more politicised senior Civil Service? (10 answers)

Answers to this question were good overall, though with a wide range, from answers which were excellent to some which were only competent. Good answers focused on the questions of improving accountability versus maintaining impartiality, but conceptualised this in a variety of different ways making for answers which came down on both sides of the issue. There were some generally good accounts of civil service history and values, incorporating discussions of the Northcote-Trevelyan, Haldane and Fulton reports. The prescribed documents relating to the civil service were used well, but the best answers contextualised this with concepts from the academic literature – e.g. using Hood's trilemma. Weaker answers struggled to define and analyse politicisation in a concrete way, sometimes failing to make the link to the 2012 reform plan and the debate surrounding it, meaning they only developed a weak grasp on what politicisation would actually entail and what has been proposed and implemented so far (e.g. on permanent secretary appointments).

5. Why have the courts in the UK become more involved in political disputes in recent years? (7 answers)

This question was very well answered, with the majority of essays reaching an excellent standard. Good answers presented well-informed overall arguments, and often incorporated very good discussion of judicial review and the Human Rights Act- including under appreciated points such as application to devolution. There was a good balance between discussion of individual cases (e.g the Miller I and II decisions) and broader issues such as the increasing complexity and ambiguity of legislation (using Williams). Some essays were also very up to date, including mention of the Faulks review and recent government attempts to roll back the scope of judicial review. Weaker answers contained some mis-characterisations of cases or offered unclear conceptualisations of the problem, for example conflating politicisation with judicial infringement on political issues.

6. Why does the UK still use First Past the Post for Westminster elections, despite myriad criticisms of it? (5 answers)

This question was well answered overall, with essays to a good standard and often including excellent analysis of the FPTP electoral system and the disproportionality inherent in it – using well evidenced examples from recent elections. The best answers also provided good analysis of the 2011 AV referendum as a critical juncture, sometimes also looking back to the Jenkins Commission. Most made a plausible and well-argued case that the electoral system is durable because the winners make the rules. Weaker answers dismissed the 2011 referendum result without explaining it, or paid excessive attention to the abstract merits of electoral systems rather than focusing on why the UK specifically has retained its system.

7. 'The insider/outsider distinction between lobby groups is at best an oversimplification and at worst misleading' (Page). Discuss. (0 answers)

No answers.

8. Why did the Labour Party fail to regain in the 2010s the popularity it enjoyed in the 2000s? (4 answers)

While there were too few answers for detailed comments on this question, essays discussed a variety of factors including issue ownership and the economy in the wake of the 2008 banking crash, leadership issues in the 2010s, and the effects of Brexit, class dealignment and values-based realignment. While some good literature on party-specific factors was included, answers were a bit superficial, often narrating events, and did not always use the literature to dig deeper

into the potential causes of the identified issues (e.g. the changes to membership and leadership contest rules on leadership).

9. To what extent were the outcomes of the 2017 and 2019 British general elections the result of realignment around the issue of Brexit? (13 answers)

This was the most answered question, with wide variation in the quality of answers from competent to excellent. All displayed a good up to date knowledge of the topic, incorporating material on both elections. Good essays used key theories from the literature to develop their answers, including long-term realignment (often, though not exclusively, using Sobolewska and Ford), electoral shocks theses (using Fieldhouse et. al.), often supplementing the account with valence voting and/or class dealignment (following Evans and Tilly). The best answers were able to cite specific key information in support of these arguments in addition to broadly summarising findings. Some also sought to combine quantitative and qualitative insights, often using Mattinson on the 'red wall'. Weaker answers paid less attention to the tension between these strands of explanation, doing less to adjudicate between competing claims, or provided a somewhat narrative and discursive account of the elections rather than leveraging the debate to make a systematic analysis. Only one essay looked in a detailed way at Scotland and its differences from England and Wales with regard to recent electoral realignments/shocks.

10. Is the UK still an over-centralised state, despite devolution to Scotland, Wales, Northern Ireland and a number of English cities and regions? (6 answers)

Answers on this question were slightly below the average standard of answers on the paper overall. There was good understanding of the structure of devolution, and explanations of development and change over time – including devolution deals in England and EVEL (though the latter was less relevant to the question). There was also some good awareness of how the politics of identity and devolution have begun to interact in England as well as Scotland (e.g using Henderson). Particularly good essays developed a clear standard for over-centralisation, however some showed a lack of clear criteria for making this judgement leading to slightly confused arguments. Analysis of devolution's effect on policy divergence was also somewhat superficial.

11. Did the Leveson Report strike the right balance between press regulation and freedom of speech? (5 answers)

This question was well answered overall, but varied from very good to competent largely depending on how close the answer stuck to the question. Good answers showed detailed knowledge of the report and recommendations, as well as the post-Leveson regulatory structure and how far it diverges from what was recommended. There were some well developed critiques based on the absence of sufficient consideration of particular issues, such as media plurality. On the other hand, some weaker essays mentioned Leveson only in general terms – instead providing a broader critique of the British media which did less to answer the specific question.

12. Did the results of the 2016 EU Referendum reveal a fundamental divergence in political culture between the nations of the UK? (2 answers)

Too few answers to comment.

205 Government and Politics of the United States

Thirteen candidates sat this paper. The overall quality of answers was high. There was a good distribution of questions attempted by the candidates, with each question receiving at least one attempted answer. Candidates demonstrated a pleasing knowledge of US government and politics, the relevant scholarly literatures and engaged with the questions posed formulating answers at the appropriate analytical level.

The quality of answers was high. The best answers (a) defined concepts/institutions carefully, (b) clarified how the question was to be defined, (c) marshalled relevant scholarly findings (citing authors, studies' findings and how they were reached, and cases), (d) developed and defended a clear argument engaged with the question posed. Good answers also showed knowledge of recent scholarly contributions in addition to the standard canon, and candidates showed an ability to criticize this work. Giving detail about the way in which scholarly research was undertaken – how variables were measured in statistical studies etc – was a sign of strength in answers. Less good answers give insufficient attention to defining the question and particularly gave insufficient attention to important conceptual terms raised in the questions.

The spread of answers was pleasing though the perennially popular topics such as the presidency or Supreme Court garnered the most answers.

Thirteen candidate sat this paper. The overall quality of answers was high. There was a good distribution of questions attempted by the candidates, with each question receiving at least one attempted answer. Candidates demonstrated a pleasing knowledge of US government and politics, the relevant scholarly literatures and engaged with the questions posed formulating answers at the appropriate analytical level.

Qu 1. "How important is democratic stability to American exceptionalism?"
4 answers. The best answers defined both AE and DS carefully and interrogated the question precisely; good answers drew on the recent scholarly literature about democratic instability in the US since 2016.

Qu 2. Federalism.
1 answer. This was a challenging question and answers needed to display good knowledge of the powers of states and localities as well as the national level of government.

Qu 3. Do political parties remain strong institutions?
4 answers. The best answers carefully defined 'strength' and drew on the relevant scholarly literature to address the question. Some very good answers.

Qu 4. Are political elites more polarised than mass publics?
3 answers. An opportunity for candidates to engage with the voting studies literature and to distinguish carefully between elites as opinion leaders and sorting institutions versus mass voter opinion.

Qu 5. The filibuster.
1 answer. A technical based question, which required candidates to demonstrate knowledge of the workings of the Senate and the wider political-institutional context.

Qu 6. Presidential power.
6 answers. Candidates defined terms carefully and most demonstrated a good knowledge of key literatures from Neustadt though Skowronek to Edwards amongst others; best answers developed sophisticated arguments about where the Trump administration sits in the arc of presidential power.

Qu 7. Balance of power between C and P.
3 answers. Candidates defined institutions carefully, cited germane scholarly literature and homed in on the constitutional context and political dynamics shaping the changes in the 'balance of power.'

Qu 8. Why has the federal budget process broken down?
1 answer. An opportunity for candidates to engage with a particular institutional dynamic and to demonstrate wide understanding of the legislative process and political constraints.

Qu 9. Interest groups.
4 answers. Candidates defined 'interest group' carefully and cited a wide range of literature about financial lobbying and advocacy groups; sophisticated answers dealt with the problem of assessing causality between funding politicians and legislative output.

Qu. 10. The Supreme Court.
7 answers. A perennially popular topic in answering which candidates demonstrated knowledge of the principal political science models (attitudinal versus strategic) of SC judicial decision making, cited relevant court decisions, and critiqued the models. Some sophisticated answers.

Qu 11. 'Colour-blind' policies versus racial inequality.
2 answers. Candidates provided detailed and knowledgeable answers, which engaged with the question, defined terms precisely and drew on extensive scholar literatures. Engaged and thoughtful discussions.

Qu 12. Decline of local media.
3 answers. Candidates attempting this question demonstrated strong understanding of the broad trends in local media decline, the significance of this decline for knowledge provision and acquisition at the local level in the US, and related it to larger political developments evident in the 21st century. Some sophisticated discussions.

206 Politics in Europe

There were four scripts of which two were excellent, one script was a high 2.1 and one achieved a grade of 65.

The quality of individual answers was generally very high.

Out of the 12 questions, six questions attracted at least one answer, and six questions received no attempts. The detailed question breakdown is as follows:

Question	Number of Answers
1	0
2	2
3	3
4	0
5	0
6	3
7	1
8	2
9	0
10	0
11	0
12	1

Specific notes on questions with a substantial number of answers:
3 This question was answered by three students. The best answers provided a systematic comparison of theoretical explanations, both in terms of the essence of core arguments and their empirical validity.
6 One of the two most popular questions, answered by three students. The best answers combined an excellent understanding of institutionalist theories of minority cabinet formation with the ability to provide illustrative evidence.

207 Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet Union

11 candidates took this examination: 9 PPE students and 2 HPol students. Overall, the students showed very good knowledge and understanding of the literature. They presented clear arguments and generally acknowledged the alternative hypotheses with some discussion of why they were unsatisfying. The strongest arguments discussed the nature of causality (problems with endogeneity etc) and sought to assess critically the core concepts. Marks ranged from 63 to 73, with an overall average of 68. Four candidates achieved a First Class mark.

Frequency of responses: low (up to 3), high (more than 3).

1) **Was Mikhail Gorbachev a transformational leader? (High)**

   Generally well answered. Candidates showed good knowledge of Gorbachev's reforms. The stronger answers engaged with the concept of transformational leadership.

2) **Did communism create the foundations for the national uprisings of the late 1980s? (High)**

   Another well answered question. Candidates showed good knowledge of the literature and nationalities policy during the Soviet period. Stronger answers discussed how elites instrumentalised nationalities policy; gave good comparative examples, and considered alternative explanations.

3) **Do 'hybrid' typologies enhance the analysis of post-Soviet political systems? (None)**

4) **How does the weakness of property rights influence political and economic behaviour in post-Soviet states? (Low)**

   The small number of students who answered this question gave good answers. The stronger scripts considered both the political and economic impacts of weak property rights. They covered business representation in politics, legal practices, and the nature of economic development.

5) **Is presidentialism perilous for post-Soviet societies? (High)**

   The stronger scripts critically assessed the extent to which Linzian arguments apply in authoritarian and hybrid contexts, and gave good examples from the region. They discussed problems of deadlock, personalization of power and rigidity (term limits).

6) **In what ways are 'dominant parties' important for post-Soviet regimes? (High)**

   Candidates gave strong answers for this question. They critically assessed the notion of 'dominant parties' and explored its application in the post-Soviet region. This involved discussing ways in which dominant parties have shaped executive dominance, patronage, legitimacy, regime consolidation.

7) **How do elections influence the politics of post-Soviet states? (Low)**

Stronger answers explored the ways in which elections strengthen executives and divide the political opposition. Few candidates considered the destabilising effects that elections can have.

8) 'Growing political protest in the former Soviet Union is evidence of democratisation.' Discuss (High)

This question produced some of the most interesting answers. Candidates discussed the extent to which protest is indicative of great political competitiveness (Ukraine, Georgia) or is a response to authoritarianism (Russia, Belarus). They also considered whether electoral revolutions have brought about genuine democratic change.

9) Are post-Soviet nationalisms rooted in ethnic appeals? (None)

10) 'The political effects of natural resources are overstated and poorly understood in the analysis of post-Soviet politics.' Discuss. (High)

Generally strong answers. Candidates discussed the central theoretical claims of this literature in the context of post-Soviet states. Arguments tended to emphasise the conditional effects of natural resources. Good country-level examples.

11) Is the pervasiveness of corruption in the former Soviet Union the legacy of communist era practices? (Low)

Few candidates tackled this question. Scripts were generally good on the competing approaches in the literature. However, little critical consideration was given to the notion of communist era 'legacies'.

12. Are the differences between post-Soviet political systems greater than their similarities (None)

208 Politics in sub-Saharan Africa Exam

As is the case with other papers, the 2021 examination again took place under circumstances affected by the global Covid pandemic. Despite this, the students answered the examinations well and demonstrated excellent knowledge and the ability to coherently structure arguments. Of the seventeen students who took the exam, six had 1st class performances and eleven were at 2:1 level. This is very positive although, as was the case in 2020, the number of outstanding performances was smaller than in previous years (there were only two scripts at 73%, both of which showed intellectual originality of the highest calibre, and none above). However, the general level remained high, with virtually no weak or disappointing scripts.

Students struggled less than was the case before 2020 to maintain consistency across all three essays and many 2.1. performances were concentrated in the upper 2.1. area. Ten questions were engaging with and two questions were not tackled by candidates. While there was less budging around certain essay topics than in previous years, the questions on structural adjustment and democratization were tackled often. There was a very good spread across many of the remaining questions, even if questions on nationalism and the politics of land attracted only one essay each. Religion, ethnicity, the political economy of development and the politics of conflict proved popular and generally attracted essays of a good standard. There was a marked improvement on the popular question on structural adjustment programmes, which resulted in 10 essays. While in the previous exam report we noted that many essays proved unimaginative and narrow, this year saw students draw on a wider range of case studies and on more interesting arguments. Despite this improvement, candidates should continue to be aware of the need to relate interesting evidence with a broader set of arguments than the ones often brought forth. The essays on gender were again consistently good, as were those on military matters. The best essays in this examination were again those that engaged the literature in a judicious and evidence-based way, rather than those that embraced well-worn positions in the literature.

Some candidates, though fewer than in the past, still lost marks for failing to define key terms or to answer all parts of a question. Those candidates that did engage with key concepts and major comparative debates in the literature developed better contributions and were rewarded accordingly. One positive aspect of this year's paper, in line with the previous years, is that students answered questions with reference to no less than thirty-one different sub-Saharan African states and showed a strong commitment to sustained comparison. The over-

concentration on one case study, and its deployment across several essays, continues to be a rare occurrence. The Francophone states of West Africa and the Horn of Africa, which were insufficiently engaged with only a few years ago, continued to see a welcome increase in references.

The candidates could still do a better job in three areas which have been flagged out in the exam reports of previous years. First, the candidates could provide a more nuanced scoping of their answer: how representative are the cases they draw on? How were the examples chosen, and how are they situated in time and space? How generalizable are the suggested conclusions? Second, candidates could make a an effort to tackle essays, especially those that lend themselves to potentially predictable treatments (especially structural adjustment and conflict), in a more deliberately original manner, both theoretically and in terms of engaging with a broader range of case-studies. Third, and perhaps most important: a number of candidates were beholden to one scholarly reference and paraphrased its contents, used the same case studies, came to similar conclusions, etc. Candidates are expected to have read widely and to have grasped the plurality of contributions to these debates.

While these points need to be kept in mind, the overall level of empirical and theoretical sophistication of this set of scripts was again commendable, especially if one bears in mind the context in which examinations were again held in 2021.

1- 1
2 – 14

3-3

4-7

5-5

6-5

7-1

8-1

9- 5

10-2

11-3

12-1

209 Contemporary Politics of Latin America

This paper was taken by thirteen PPE candidates and one HPol candidate. This was another different year, given the continuing pandemic and the move to online exams but in the end, many of the scripts proved to be of very high quality. There were four clear first-class honours, together with ten upper seconds and no lower seconds. All of the scripts demonstrated a very good understanding of the wider theoretical literature and as is always the case with this exam, the stronger scripts matched this theoretical knowledge with solid empirical knowledge. The very best scripts could successfully critically engage with the theoretical models and could illustrate the theoretical dynamics with reference to the actual politics of the region. The weaker scripts struggled to engage with some of the more complicated theoretical ideas in the literature and these scripts also struggled to demonstrate empirical knowledge. Below is the distribution of answers, by question:

Question	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
N	3	3	5	3	10	5	2	2	1	3	2	3

This year all questions on the exam were attempted, reflecting the increasing trend for a greater spread in the choice of questions among candidates over the last couple of years. Although the spread was generally even, one question, Question 5 on the electoral success of the left, was considerably more popular than any other. Questions 3 (on state capacity) and 6 (on economic reform) also proved popular. Question 11 (on party systems) produced some of the strongest answers this year.

211 Politics of the Middle East

Overall, this year, the essays were more substantial in their arguments and denser regarding the content they provided. Students also integrated multiple sources into their writings. This is not surprising as students have adapted to (and heavily prepared for) the open-book style exams. As a result, we did not have a considerable variation in grades. Most scripts were at the stronger end of 67, with nine earning a distinction. There were only two scripts below 60.

The questions varied in detail, with some making use of only one or two cases to exemplify their arguments, while others were drawing from a wide range of Middle Eastern countries. Citations followed academic conventions in the stronger scripts, with some even writing article-style texts rather than the hand-written essays that we usually see, including direct quotes from several authors. Only a few scripts did not quote any authors and relied more on making their own argument. The strongest essays combined a mix of both, integrated relevant established works and weighed their arguments critically based on and departing from them.

Students chose a variety of questions, with some more popular than others.

Several people selected the question of whether "the state is the most enduring legacy of colonialism", with almost all answers arguing that the state is one but not the only enduring colonial legacy. Stronger answers traced "the state" back to its colonial inception, defined it and established its durability to the present day. The strongest answers discussed other colonial legacies and clearly distinguished them from the "state" or laid out which features of the state can be traced back to specific colonial practices.

Another popular question was "whether orientalist views continue to distort the study of the Middle East?". The best answers showed how several issue debates - such as feminism and gender, and explanations for the lack of democracy in the Middle East - are framed by orientalism and laid out how these may be viewed differently without these lenses.

The question about "No taxation, no representation" was the question answered by most students, with a majority of answers arguing that it is a central but not the only explanation for the lack of democracy within the Middle East. Strong answers made comparisons with other resource-rich regions of the world and Middle Eastern countries with taxation but no representation either. The usual answer combined the rentier effect with the repression effect to conclude that taxes alone cannot account for the lack of democracy in the Middle East.

Several students also discussed a related political economy question "How important has the concept of rent been to the region's socio-economic development?" Their answers looked at the wider socio-economic effects, with weak answers only focusing on the political economy and recent diversification efforts. Strong responses addressed the impact of rents on society, classes, political structures and compared these with Middle Eastern countries with no rents. Very strong answers focussed not only on oil rents but also foreign aid and semi-rentier states.

The question of "Do you agree that Arab Nationalism and Political Islam have promised much and delivered little?" was very popular and gave rise to wide-ranging debates with strong answers laying out what each promised (ideological programme) and what they delivered (practical application) – and then coming to their own conclusion when comparing them.

Less popular were these two questions, selected only by two students each: “Did Pan-Arabism provide the legitimacy for military rule in the Middle East? “. “Is ‘Islamic democracy’ a viable alternative to ‘liberal democracy’?”

Several students discussed whether “Arab societies more adequately characterized as ‘ethnic’ rather than ‘civil societies’?”. Strong answers included a definition of “civil society”, clearly delineating from ethnic group perceptions.

The question on “Is sub-state or supranational identity the stronger competitor for territorial national identity in the Middle East?” was selected by some students with answers weighing the role of a regional Arab identity versus diverse national identities against the continuing influence of sub-state ethnic and sectarian divisions.

A handful of students also discussed whether “Sectarianism is the most powerful driver of conflict in the Middle East.” Most students answered with reference to the Syrian war, Lebanon, and/or the Sunni-Shia divide, or the Arab/Palestinian-Israeli conflict, arguing that sectarianism is politically manipulated and created, thus fuelling rather than sparking conflict.

Selected by many students was also the question on “Is ‘Islamic feminism’ a contradiction in terms?”. Arguably a tricky question, with weaker answers only discussing the compatibility between Islamic texts and women’s rights. Whereas stronger answers were weighing the goals of different strains of feminist thinking discussing gender roles and their social construction and the unsettled debates ranging around equality and difference.

Very popular was also the last question on the Arab Spring: “Do the outcomes of the Arab Spring events signify a radical change in Middle Eastern politics or continuation of the same political trends?” Strong answers traced continuities before and after 2011 or argued for a radical break by showing a difference between pre- and post-Arab Spring politics, employing several different examples instead of only Tunisia and Egypt.

212 International Relations in the Era of Two World Wars

Overall candidates performed well on this paper with a good standard of knowledge and argument demonstrated consistently across the board. Fifteen candidates sat the paper and the mean mark awarded was 67.6. As is common, candidates clustered around a more limited range of questions. Stronger candidates were able to engage fully with the question as asked, and to demonstrate the ability both to account for the origins of the world wars and topics covering matters other than state security.

Q.1 *Do realist theories of international relations provide the best explanation for the outbreak of World War One?*
[7 candidates answered]
A popular question, with some good but no outstanding answers. Candidates were able to give some good arguments regarding realist accounts but only some attempted a full comparison or contrast with other possible theoretical approaches. There was little or no attempt to link to Leninist or constructivist arguments regarding international order and the outbreak of war.

Q.2 *Was Woodrow Wilson an 'idealist' in his approach to international relations?*
[4 candidates answered]
Some average answers here. Candidates had good knowledge of Wilson, the Fourteen Points and the League and its Mandates system. But candidates did not make the link to reasons for the USA entering the First World War, or examine any contradiction between Wilson's international liberalism and domestic racism, though the lack of a racial equality clause in the Treaty of Versailles was mentioned.

Q.3 *How similar, and how different, were France and Britain in the roles they played in Middle East during the inter-war period?*
[3 candidates answered]
Only a limited number of answers, which mainly concentrated on the League of Nations Mandate system in the region with little mention of Britain's role in Egypt or the notion of "Britain's moment in the Middle East".

Q.4 *Did the USSR follow Marxist principles in its foreign policy between 1917 and 1941?*
[6 candidates answered]
A popular topic which drew a range of responses. There was some good knowledge of Marx, Lenin and Trotsky's goals but weaker answers did not extend the discussion to consider Stalin. Candidates were strong on dividing Soviet foreign policy into chronological periods, with the best answers seeing later events like the Molotov-Ribbentrop pact in the light of the earlier periods.

Q.5 *Assess the relative importance of external and internal factors in shaping US foreign policy during the 1920s and 1930s.*
[1 candidate answered]
Too few answers to comment.

Q.6 *Were the Locarno Agreements the 'real dividing line between the years of war and the peace that is to follow' (Austen Chamberlain)?*
[2 candidates answered]
Too few answers to comment.

Q.7 *What caused the Manchurian Crisis of 1931-33?*
[1 candidate answered]
Too few answers to comment.

Q.8 *Were attempts to apply the principle of national self-determination a stabilising or destabilising factor in Central and Eastern Europe during the inter-war period?*
[1 candidate answered]
Too few answers to comment.

Q.9 *How far were efforts to make Germany pay reparations for World War One responsible for the instability of the inter-war economic system?*
[2 candidates answered]
Too few answers to comment.

Q.10 *In what ways, and to what extent, did ideology shape German foreign policy under the Nazis?*
[7 candidates answered]
One of the most popular topics, drawing an interesting variety of answers with some outstanding marks. Weaker candidates were reluctant to tackle the question of Nazism's hostility to Bolshevism or its antisemitism, instead showing a strong focus on the drive for *Lebensraum*. Stronger answers showed excellent treatment of the problem in terms of both classic and contemporary literature and how ideological dogmatism might have 'distorted' German foreign policy from pursuit of national interest.

Q.11 *Did the League of Nations change the nature of international order in any significant way?*
[7 candidates answered]
Again a popular topic with a range of marks, some very high. Many candidates had very good knowledge of the League's more prominent episodes and the stronger answers made the case for the League's successes in laying the foundations of a post-WWII liberal order even if it could not be credited with remaking it before 1939. Stronger answers also showed deeper understanding of how the League's affiliated international institutions might have contributed to economic stability or human welfare.

Q.12 *How did new military technologies affect the strategies of combatants in World War Two?*
[1 candidate answered]
Too few answers to comment.

213 International Relations in the Era of the Cold War

23 candidates (22 PPE; 1 HP)

The numbers are consistent with the previous four years and remain strong. No particular issue arose. The general standard was high: seven candidates achieved first-class marks, and sixteen obtained 2.is. There were no 2.iis or lower marks. The best answers to all questions successfully combined analytical depth with knowledge of the relevant historiography.

Most candidates chose to answer at least one or two questions from the first section of the paper. This is unsurprising, given the structure of the paper, and in line with previous years. Among the questions on thematic and regional aspects, the most popular answers were to questions 5 (China), 12 (the Middle East), and 10 (Eastern Europe). No candidate attempted question 6 (Japan) and question 7 (Western Europe).

Question-specific comments:

1. *Did the Cold War start in Europe?*

The second most popular question (11 answers). Answers were generally good, with three first-class answers. Many candidates treated the question as a generic one on the origins of the Cold War. A few included detailed discussion of the Cold War outside of Europe.

2. *'Neither containment nor peaceful coexistence changed the fundamental structures of Cold War competition.' Discuss.*

A popular question, with good answers (7). One candidate wrote a first-class answer, and a few more obtained high 2.is. Lower marks were due to the fact that those candidates focused mostly on one aspect (containment or peaceful coexistence) while providing only limited discussion of the other one.

3. *Was there a difference between 'superpower détente' and 'European détente'?*

One of the most popular questions (10 answers), with three first-class essays and several in the high 2.i range. All candidates discussed both aspects of détente effectively. Most argued that there was a significant difference between the two.

4. *Did the Soviet Union need to collapse for the Cold War to end?*

The most popular question (16 answers), with 3 first-class essays and a few in the 2.i range,. While most candidates stressed the role of the Soviet leadership in the process, they also analysed external reasons that contributed to the dissolution of the USSR. In general, most candidates chose a balanced approach to this question.

5. *'Between 1945 and 1991, the People's Republic of China's foreign policy was guided more by domestic politics than by the Global Cold War.' Discuss*

A very popular question, with 10 answers. Candidates did generally quite well (2 first class answers and several in the high 2.i range), combining discussion of some of the key events with analyses of doctrine and leadership. There was no general consensus in the answers, and candidates took very different approaches in explaining the PRC's foreign policy during the Cold War. As in other cases, the very best answers showed knowledge of the key historiography.

6. *To what extent was Japan part of the Cold War West between 1945 and 1991?*

No answers.

7. *Did Western Europe have a 'special relationship' with the United States during the Cold War?*

No answers.

8. *Was European integration and anti-communist political project?*

Only one answer.

9. *'The Cold War was a continuation of colonialism through slightly different means.' (Westad). Discuss.*

Just like in previous years, relatively few candidates attempted the question on this topic (3 answers), but those who did achieved good results (2 first-class answers and 1 very high 2.i). The best answers combined discussion of the nature of Cold War and of decolonisation.

10. *Was Soviet domination of Eastern Europe destined to end?*

Five answers, with no first-class essays but all in the 2.i range. The best answers focus on the continuities and change of Soviet domination and addressed Soviet reason to remain involved in the region until the end.

11. *'The strength of communist movements in Southeast Asia made the region a site of violent Cold War confrontation.' Discuss.*

Only two answers.

12. *To what extent did superpower intervention drive conflict in the Middle East between 1945 and 1991?*

Four candidates attempted this question, with most marks in the first or high 2.i range. As in previous years, the best answers gave a nuanced view of the Cold War in the Middle East, showing knowledge of both local development and global trends. Historiography remains a key aspect of this topic.

214 International Relations

The IR core paper was once again very popular with students. The overall quality of the answers was very high and there were very few truly bad performances. Faculty graders felt that the exam was fair and were generally pleased with the answers. They had the usual comments regarding what made for better/worse answers.

I asked Musashi Harukawa (who did the overall analysis of the PPE grades) to break out the data on the IR paper and the following comments combine some of this findings with comments from the graders. I focus on a major criticism that should be actionable.

The answers were distributed across the questions very unevenly. The three most popular questions (4-Power; 10-UN/Security; 12-Clash) accounted for 55% of all responses while the three least popular questions (2-Law; 3-Critical; 6-Institutions) accounted for only7% of responses. Of particular concern is that reasonable facsimiles of the most popular questions have appeared fairly consistently over past exams – and have been available to guide students in their preparations. By contrast, the least answered questions were arguably more novel questions that have not been asked repeatedly over the years. This raises the prospect that students have been able to narrow the scope of their revisions by anticipating a small number of questions. Especially in the context of an open-book exam but even in a more traditional closed-book exam, it further raises the possibility that students might rely on pre-prepared boilerplate to be adapted to the specific variant of the questions. This would seem to go completely against the "spirit" of an Oxford exam!
A possible variation of this argument is that tutors are not teaching the whole course but rather concentrating on a few topics. One grader noted that the authors cited also concentrated on a very small subset of the course reading list.
Finally, some graders were concerned that question 10 on UN/security potentially overlapped the special paper on international security (297).
These problems should be rectified for next year's exam. Old questions should be retired and not re-issued in slightly amended form that students can readily anticipate. Overlap with other courses (297) should be avoided. Above all, questions should be innovative and challenge students to show a knowledge of, and ability to combine, materials from different parts of the reading. This may make the exam questions less formulaic and therefor a bit harder to grade but has the compensating advantage that the process should be less mind-numbing for the graders as well.

215 Plato to Rousseau

Overall remarks

This paper had 20 scripts this year, near the average student number over the past few years (though down from last year). The range of scores was also diminished compared to last year: fewer high first-class scripts – last year seemed exceptional in his regard – but fewer scores on the low end as well.

The lowest scores were either due to incomplete answers or scripts that did not demonstrate sufficient knowledge of at least three authors from the primary reading. We want to stress to students (and tutors) that this is a minimum requirement. Students must also be wary of material overlap between answers dedicated to single-thinker questions (usually 1-9) and the comparative/thematic questions (10-12). However, this remark is not meant to deter students from attempting answers to the latter.

Indeed, in the lectures this academic year there was a greater emphasis placed on conceptual subjects: on issues of utopia, civic virtue, natural law and natural rights, as well as 'the personal' in relation to 'the political'. By comparison to previous years, then, there were slightly fewer lectures dedicated to single authors (from the usual two to only one on Machiavelli, Hobbes, and Locke respectively).

While the exam questions followed the normal format, maintaining the usual one-question-per-core-author offering, there were (again) disappointingly few responses to the additional conceptual questions. Nor did considerations on themes from the conceptual lectures and readings filter into many of the single-author answers. This was an opportunity missed. Students are encouraged to entertain material – and attend lectures – not solely dedicated to the three authors they choose to concentrate on.

On all answers, though, as in past years, the strongest responses showed independent judgement and a careful reading of the texts to support a well-articulated argument. The best answers also integrated important historical context in support of the textual analysis: in particular, in paying attention to what and to whom an author was responding to in the circumstances. Boilerplate historical background at times did more harm than good, however. Strong answers also addressed scholarly debates, demonstrating engagement with secondary reading beyond introductory texts.

Weaker answers often offered few or no references to the core texts. In other instances, answers were bereft of any analysis of text quoted or cited. This said, indiscriminate cutting-and-pasting of long sections of text was less of a problem this year compared to last. Answers over-reliant on lecture material and introductory books suffered for it.

Lastly, as in most years, answers clustered around particular authors (Plato, Machiavelli, Hobbes – and this year especially, Rousseau). While students should not be deterred from answering questions on the authors that most interest and inspire them, those that ventured further afield – answering questions on Aquinas and Montesquieu, in particular – had an easier time standing out.

Individual remarks

1. Is it a problem for Plato's Socrates, who claims no contradiction between justice and self- interest, that the Kallipolis requires philosophers to rule (Republic 519 c-d), while they, being philosophers, do not see it as in their best interest to do so?

A popular question, but some of the answers were exceptional. The best answers addressed how we should approach this passage – and consider the character dynamics going on – in relation to arguments elsewhere in the book, and also in relation to Plato's *Apology* (a short work that we encourage students to read alongside the *Republic*). Strong answers also linked this later passage with careful consideration of arguments in Book I.

2. Can we best understand Aristotle's normative aim in the Politics as a call for moderation?

A split between some very high scores and many low seconds reflects that many struggled to link the issue of 'moderation' – a broad (and provocative) theme – with specific passages and arguments in the text. Others spoke in insufficient generalities. Strong answers considered moderation in character in relation to institutions and laws. Those with a familiarity with Aristotle's *Ethic*s benefitted from this, but strong answers needed not refer to it.

3. If, as Aquinas says, 'the ultimate happiness and felicity of every intellectual substance is to know God' (Summa contra Gentiles), then what role does this leave for politics in his thought?

This question referred to themes discussed in a [long] lecture from MT considering the role of the state in the thinking of Aquinas set in relation/contrast to Augustine and Aristotle. There were only two responses to this question, but both did well to engage with Aquinas' thinking (via consideration of both his *Summa* [on law] and *De Regno*) in relation to Aristotle in particular.

4. 'Where there is no justice, there is no republic' (Saint Augustine, City of God). Would Machiavelli agree?

This proved to be a difficult question on a popular author. The best answers focused on the importance of – and relationship between – good laws and good arms in a well-ordered state. A strong understanding of the *Discourses* was especially important.

5. Does Hobbes' theory of a subject's 'liberty to disobey' (Leviathan Chapter 21), in fact give the individual 'the right to decide whether obedience is worth it' (Ryan)?

A very popular question with a wide range of scores. The best answers engaged the scholarly literature on this key issue – on exactly what is retained in the transfer of right – and also considered the question from different angles, including in terms of the psychology and obligations of the subject vis a vis Sovereign. Unfortunately, many of the answers displayed errors in understanding Hobbes' discussion of things like covenant, will and rights.

6. Should Locke's justification of empire disqualify him as a liberal?

Students produced many thoughtful and wide-ranging responses to this question. The issue of Locke and empire was the subject of the Carlyle Lectures this year (advertised via the lectures for this course). This offered those who watched the lectures a slight advantage (even if this subject is prominent in the scholarly literature on the reading list). However, some candidates did not go beyond re-explaining what was said by Professor Goldie, bringing down their mark considerably.

7. ‘The political men of Greece who lived under popular government recognized no other force to sustain it than virtue. Those of today speak to us only of manufacturing, commerce, finance, wealth, and even luxury’ (Montesquieu). For Montesquieu, then, is commerce anathema to civic virtue?

This question spoke to material covered in the Montesquieu and civic virtue lectures. Few answers; however some were of high-first standard.

8. Can Hume square his theory that allegiance is not a matter of agreement with his theory that human conduct is governed by self-interest?

Too few answers to comment.

9. Should we consider Rousseau to be a conservative thinker?

A very popular question. The better answers referred to a wider range of Rousseau’s work (beyond Social Contract) and showed appreciation for the different ways to evaluate this question. Weaker answers did not; or they spent too much time discussing the anatomy of the concept of conservatism.

Questions 10, 11, 12

Too few answers to comment on each question. Though some first-class answers should remind candidates of the possibility for scoring very well on these thematic questions.

216 Political Thought: Bentham to Weber

This was a good year for Bentham to Weber. Of 13 scripts no paper received lower than a 2:1 mark and there were three papers with an overall first-class mark. Several candidates received first class marks on at least one question. As usual, the very best papers achieved a well-balanced trifecta of primary, secondary and contextual knowledge while offering clear and cogent arguments in response to the question. It is especially pleasing when it is clear that candidates have closely engaged with the primary texts. It is worth reiterating last year's warning that candidates are reminded that while it is excellent to motivate arguments and evidence claims with passages of text, passages of text are no substitute for exegesis itself.

1. Was Saint Simon a technocrat?

Saint Simon got a fair amount of attention this year. The strongest answers attended to the changes in his arguments over the years -- including showing some quite extraordinarily detailed textual analysis -- and some asked how appropriate a category like 'technocrat' was for assessing his views.

2. Is there any sense in which Bentham was a theorist of modern democracy?

This question solicited three answers. All answers did a good job of stipulating what the candidate took to be at stake in the question. The key is not to spend so much time considering what it means to be a theorist of modern democracy that you forget to write much about Bentham's own political thought.

3. What was the relevance of Ancient Greece to Hegel’s political thought?

This question was answered once and as such it is inappropriate to comment.

4. Was Marx a theorist of freedom as non-domination?

This was a pretty popular question that solicited a range of answers. Candidates tended not to engage with the new 'radical republicanism' literature but many decent answers did address the notion of 'neo-Roman' or 'republican' liberty and its usefulness in understanding Marx's thought.

5. Why did Tocqueville think associations so important for American democracy?

Another popular question that, on the whole, didn't elicit much by way of searching or challenging responses. Candidates tended to remain at the level of description and are reminded that deceptively 'easy' questions like this one do leave open an opportunity to critically engage with an author's views as well as merely to describe them. It was a pity that so few candidates took this up in relation to this question.

6. To what degree was gender a preoccupation of Mill’s political thought?

Candidates did well arguing both the positive and negative cases in relation to this question. These answers were a good reminder that what matters most is not the interpretation you

offer, but how well you back up your claims and how thoughtfully you engage with the question.

7. Is there room for socialism in the thought of Max Weber?

This was not a popular question, but the answers given were stunningly good. Candidates showed detailed, expert knowledge of Weber's views on socialism, and engaged critically with the internal consistency of his arguments as well as trying to situate them in context.

8. What, for Durkheim, threatened social solidarity?

Another question with very strong answers. Unlike the Tocqueville question, candidates tended to take what appears a simple descriptive question and use it to explore some of the finer nuances of Durkheim's thought.

9. Was the 19th century the period of 'the secularization of the European mind'? Answer with reference to AT LEAST TWO authors you have studied for this paper.

10. Did 19th century thinkers fear or revere the individual? Answer with reference to AT LEAST TWO authors you have studied for this paper.

11. To what extent was an interest in history a sign of the desire to defend the status quo among 19th century thinkers? Answer with reference to AT LEAST TWO authors you have studied for this paper.

12. What did 19th century thinkers believe you could learn from scrutinising the family? Answer with reference to AT LEAST TWO authors you have studied for this paper.

As in previous years, there were too few responses to most of the comparative questions to offer individual assessments. The exception was question 10, which received four very strong responses.

Overall, it remains true that the weakest answers chose to use these questions as an occasion for the author's own sometimes quite disparate speculations on the theme of the question. Candidates are again reminded that these questions are meant to be an occasion to meditate on any of the 19th and 20th century authors that they have read for the course in as detailed and as nuanced a way as is possible. There is more than one way of writing a good comparative answer. Some show knowledge of a wide range of texts, some of which were not on the reading list. Other excellent answers offer a close reading of just two of the set authors. There are many ways to do well on these questions, but the best answers showed a close attention to detail and a clear command of the texts that they chose to discuss.

217 Marx and Marxism

Q. 1. ‘Marx’s writings are incomprehensible without an understanding of Hegel’s influence on them, whether one considers that influence to be harmful or beneficial.’ Discuss.

[Too few answers to comment.]

Q. 2. Is it possible or desirable to separate Marx’s understanding of alienation from his account of human nature?

Comment: This was a popular question. Better candidates considered: why it might be thought desirable to separate the concept of alienation from a particular model of human nature; and, more generally, what might substitute for models of human nature as a criteria for ‘inappropriate’ separation.

Q. 3. Does Marx provide a clear and consistent account of the role of class, and of class struggle, in his theory of history?

Comment: Another popular question. Many candidates spent too much of the essay sketching a general account of the theory of history, and not enough answering the precise question. Surprisingly few candidates treated class and class struggle as distinct categories.

Q. 4. ‘Marx is inconsistent in being both a fierce critic of capitalism, and a fervent enthusiast for industry and technology.’ Discuss.

[Too few answers to comment.]

Q. 5. What is Marx seeking to explain with his theory of ideology?

Comment: Candidates might have thought more, and more carefully, about alternative explanations (*explanans*) for their account of that which needs to be explained (*explanandum*). For some e*xplananda*, ideological explanations might look, either redundant, or one of several available (and compatible) explanations.

Q. 6. ‘Freedom consists in converting the state from an organ superimposed upon society into one completely subordinate to it’ (Critique of the Gotha Programme). Discuss.

Comment: A popular question. A disappointing large proportion of candidates rehearsed somewhat general Marx and the state answers, ignoring or neglecting the specific question asked.

Q. 7. ‘Marx maintains that communism has many advantages over capitalism, but never suggests that communism is morally superior to capitalism.’ Discuss.

Comment: A popular question. A disappointingly large proportion of candidates rehearsed somewhat general Marx and morality answers, ignoring or neglecting the specific question asked. Surprisingly few candidates appeared to have thought carefully, in advance, about whether, and how, they might want to distinguish the concepts of normative, moral, and just.

Q. 8. Do Marx and Engels think that there is anything positive to be learnt from the 'utopian socialists'?

Comment: Few candidates demonstrated much first-hand familiarity with the writings of particular 'utopian socialists'. Some answers remained rather too broad, and had little specific to say about the variety of possible 'positive lessons' here.

Q. 9. 'Bernstein rightly insists that Marx's writings are not only empirically outdated, but also contaminated by "Blanquism" and "Hegelianism".' Discuss.

Comment: Most answers dealt with the 'empirically outdated' complaint effectively. Better answers typically had more detailed comments on the supposed 'Blanquist' and 'Hegelian' elements in Marx's writings, and sought to explain why Bernstein judged them problematic.

Q. 10. 'Lenin's account of the relation between party and class may be less attractive than Luxemburg's, but it is more realistic.' Discuss.

Comment: Responses were varied in quality. Some candidates appeared to have found the 'greater realism' part of the claim somewhat easier to engage with than the 'less attractive' part.

11. 'Of those Marxists concerned with the future prospects for socialism in Russia, none of them took the international dimension of revolution seriously enough.' Discuss with reference to TWO OR MORE of the authors you have studied for this paper.

[Too few answers to comment.]

Q. 12. 'Gramsci is best understood as a theorist of defeat; his Prison Notebooks help explain the failure of socialist revolutions in the West, but offer little hope for future success.' Discuss.

Comment: Convincing first-hand knowledge of Gramsci's own writings was in short supply, even amongst otherwise well-informed accounts of his ideas. There was surprisingly little *critical* engagement with Gramsci's strategic recommendations.

218 Sociological Theory

Sixteen candidates took this paper, including three from History and Politics. Given the online exam format and the disruption caused by COVID-19, it was reassuring to see that the quality of most scripts was commendably high. One script was marked as third class and another as second class, lower division; the remainder were in the second class, upper division or first class. The best answers demonstrated extensive reading and original insights. Q2 (rationality) was the most popular, with eleven answers. Q7 (evolutionary psychology and social networks) and Q8 (values) each attracted six answers, while Q4 (gender and interaction) and Q12 (methodological individualism versus holism) each attracted five. Four candidates answered Q1 (status). There were three answers to each of Q5 (race and functionalism), Q6 (social construction), and Q11 (cooperation). Two candidates answered Q3 (inequality).

220 Political Sociology

The average standard of the scripts was relatively high with good knowledge of the literature shown by most candidates. The worst answers, as always, were either assemblies of anecdotes about current affairs which did not adequately discuss the academic literature or answers which failed to focus on the particular question asked. This year it was the latter which predominated among the weaker answers.

1) Generally competently answered. Better answers discussed how trust does, or does not, relate to social capital.

2) Some good answers to this question. The best discussed in detail the different mechanisms whereby politicians' backgrounds might affect class voting and made clear the distinction between class voting based on policy versus class voting based on class as a social identity.

3) The best answers to this question discussed, in the round, economic inequalities between men and women and the ways in which these might affect a variety of political outcomes (participation, vote choice, political attitudes and knowledge/ interest). Weaker answers discussed legislative representation at length which was somewhat tangential to the question.

4) Many candidates failed to adequately define political integration which made answering the question difficult. Weaker answers assumed that political integration meant standing as candidates in elections rather than mass integration into the party and political system in a more general way.

5) Good answers carefully defined populism, the policy stances of radical right parties and the relative appeal of both. The best answers talked about the links between the appeal of specific policies and populism at the voter level.

6) Few answers to this question. Some weaker candidates appeared to choose to answer a different question on turnout.

7) Few answers to this question. Better answers made suitable reference to the key works in the field and also discussed ethnic versus civic nationalism.

8) Few answers to this question. Difficulties occurred with regard to defining and empirically capturing politicization. Weaker answers exclusively focused on institutional and supply-side factors with little discussion of the interplay between demand and supply.

9) Better answers carefully distinguished post-materialism from social liberalism and considered whether both the purported causes and outcomes of post-materialist change were helpful in understanding the world. Weaker answers were often very reliant on Inglehart but also failed to adequately describe post-materialism.

10) Good answers carefully delineated the ways in which citizens can influence policy and compared the likely influence of economic elites and the average person. The best answers considered which of these perceived routes to influence actually affect policy outcomes.

11) Few answers to this question. Better answers specified what “caring” means and then connected this to the debate between those who favour explanatory variables centred on altruism and culture and those who emphasize economic self-interest.

12) There were too few answers to provide general comments about this question.

224 Social Policy

This paper was taken by 26 students. All questions were answered by at least one student, but there was a high concentration of answers on a few questions. The most popular questions were those focusing on poverty (Q3), education (Q8) and the welfare mix (Q12). Less than three students addressed the questions on housing (Q6), social policy analysis (Q4) and pensions (Q1). The average mark was 65 (lowest 58, highest 76).

The strongest answers showed breadth of knowledge and understanding of both theory and policies, made use of relevant examples and evidence, developed analytical arguments and demonstrated independent thinking. The weakest answers were poorly written and/or structured, made use of limited material, relied excessively on direct quotations, remained descriptive and contained significant mistakes of interpretation or lacked focused on the question.

Q	**1**	**2**	**3**	**4**	**5**	**6**	**7**	**8**	**9**	**10**	**11**	**12**
A	1	4	17	2	5	1	8	12	8	3	6	11

Q2 (unemployment benefits),

Fewer students answered this question. The best answers provided a comprehensive and well-structured discussion of the effect of unemployment insurance on different aspects of labour market functioning, discussed poverty traps and moral hazard and made use of analytical dimensions (generosity, duration, eligibility) and comparative evidence. The poorest answers demonstrated knowledge of core material but lacked focus on the question and/or breadth.

Q3 (poverty)

This was the most popular question (22% of answers). The best answers demonstrate an excellent command of material, provided analytical discussion of targeting vs. universalism, differentiated between notions of poverty, considered different dimensions of outcomes and the political consequences of targeted benefits. The poorest answers contained mistakes, relied on limited sources and evidence and lacked breadth.

Q5(emergence of the welfare state in the UK)

The best answers discussed different factors that led to the emergence of the British welfare state, build an analytical argument about the interconnectedness of industrialization and political mobilization and referred to a good range of historical evidence and theoretical accounts. The poorest answers include relevant material but lacked a secure grasp on the topic, demonstrate a weak understanding and/or failed to build a coherent answer.

Q7 (welfare regimes)

The best answers demonstrated breadth of knowledge, understanding of both welfare regimes and feminist critique, refer to a wide range of relevant sources and made an effective use of concepts (e.g. citizenship, defamilialization) to build a cogent argument. The weakest answers demonstrated knowledge of core material but limited understanding of the topic, contained mistakes and/or were more limited in breadth or remained focused solely on issues relating to classification.

Q8 (education)

The best answers demonstrated an in-depth understanding of education policies in the UK under different governments, referred to key pieces of legislation, went beyond mere description of policies to critically appraise notions such as parental choice or league tables. The weakest answers demonstrated knowledge of core policies in the field of education but failed to demonstrate a secure grasp on the topic, lacked breadth and/or remained descriptive.

Q9 (family policies)

The best answers provided a nuanced interpretation of the drivers of family policies carefully distinguishing between motives relating to child poverty and female labour market activation,

demonstrated knowledge of a range of policy measures initiated under different government and used theoretical knowledge to assess these developments. The weakest answers demonstrated knowledge of a limited set of policies and material, remained descriptive or focused on child poverty rather than family policies or generally lacked focused on the question.

Q10 (health policies)

Fewer students answered this question. The best answers demonstrated command of the literature on health inequalities and knowledge of key pieces of legislation and theories. The weakest answers showed understanding of core material but missed core references, failed to build a coherent argument, did not demonstrate understanding of the social gradient of health/health gap, and remained descriptive.

Q11(immigration)

The strongest answers developed complex arguments, dealt with several aspects of the questions, contrasted different perspectives and referred to studies on a wide range of issues such as multiculturalism, solidarity, deservingness and the role of politics. They relied on a wide range of sources and demonstrated independent thinking with some occasional weakness of interpretation. The weakest answers showed weak understanding of the question, made use of limited material, made an excessive use of direct quotations, failed to develop a coherent argument and/or contained mistakes.

Q12 (welfare mix)

The best answers provided a nuanced interpretation of shifts in the UK welfare mix under different governments and considered and critically evaluated policy developments on different aspects (market, third sector, families). The weakest answers showed understanding of core material but were more limited in breadth, remained descriptive or failed to build a coherent argument, relied on limited material and/or contained significant mistakes.

This report does not include the analysis of the scripts of five human sciences students.

225 Comparative Demographic Systems

This paper was taken by 6 candidates in 2021. Continuing with the trend in the past three years, performance on quantitative demography part of the paper (Part A) was consistently strong. Students demonstrated a solid understanding of life table concepts to describe mortality patterns and were able to interpret and contextualise the measures they had calculated well. Some of the interpretive questions in Part A would have benefitted from further engagement and discussion of the broader literature on the drivers of improvements in mortality and population health, and a better integration of knowledge learned across both parts A and B of the paper.

For Part B of the paper, essay questions linked to topics in the low fertility were very popular. In particular, the question on whether the levels of remarkably low fertility in Europe seen in the 1990s and early 2000s can be characterized as a period phenomenon was answered by nearly all candidates. Another area of interest was the role of population policies in influencing fertility patterns in the context of post-transitional low fertility. The essays demonstrated a good understanding of the broader context of the factors and theoretical perspectives explaining the onset of sub-replacement fertility, as well as the measurement issues linked to analysis of fertility. The strongest essays across all topics were those that integrated both the theoretical explanations with empirical examples, as well as discussions of measurement issues and research design.

227 Politics of China

General Comments: This year, we had both a larger and more varied class than usual, with a total of twenty-four students sitting the exam, which included students reading PPE as well as History and Politics. The range of preparation and experience among the students sitting the exam, particularly given the shift to online teaching and exams, was quite mixed, which was reflected in final marks. Most candidates opted to answer a combination of questions that covered a different elements of the course. Successful responses demonstrated a good balance of factual knowledge, critical analysis and understanding of relevant issues; the most successful answers and scripts provided excellent depth of engagement with specific scholarly literature (in terms of both concepts and arguments). Scripts that received lower marks either provided answers that were too brief, poorly organised, or did not demonstrate a familiarity with the relevant scholarly literature/assigned readings on a given topic.

Comments on individual questions: The most popular questions for candidates tended to be either those that called for an evaluation of a historically specific event or a particular policy and its consequences, or those that addressed a clearly delineated debate within the subfield of Chinese politics. Popular topics included evaluations of Mao's policy choices during the Cultural Revolution or the Great Leap Forward; the question on the reinvention of China's state-owned enterprises as "national champions," the question on protest and repression, and on China's accession to the WTO. Less popular topics included questions that are regarded by the PRC government as more politically sensitive, such as those about the 1989 protest movement, the role of faith-based charities in providing social welfare, and the United Front Work Department. On the other hand, the "sensitive" question of economic integration of Hong Kong and Taiwan proved surprisingly popular, including a few answers that merited top marks.

228 Politics of the EU

14 students sat this paper in June 2021, 2 HP and 12 PPE students. Five exams reached an overall mark above 70 (highest mark 75) and nine exams were above 60 (upper second). The mean was 67.9 in 2021 (compared to 66.1 in 2020). HP students (average 68) did just slightly better on average than PPE students (average 67.9). This result is comparable and just slightly higher compared to the 2020 exam, when two of 10 exams reached a grade above 70, and seven exams were above 60 and one exam was marked with 59 (lower second) with a mean of 66.1.

The distribution of answers was as follows:

Question	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
number of answers	2	4	5	3	3	5		4	5	7	2	2

Students had to answer 3 out of 12 essay questions and the distribution of chosen questions ensured that students had to draw on diverse set of topics that had been covered throughout the course. Some questions tend to be a little more popular than others, but importantly students have covered a wide breadth of topics and questions.

Q10. To what extent has the UK been an 'awkward partner' for the other member states of the EU? (7 x answered) was the most popular question, followed by Q3. How has the balance of power between the Council of the European Union and the European Parliament changed (5 x answered) and Q6. How democratic is the EU? (5 x answered) and 9. What kind of power is the EU? (5 x answered), followed by Q2 on the relevance of Neofunctionalism (4x answered) and Q8 on the nature of Common Foreign and Security Policy (4 x answered). The least popular were Q1 on liberal intergovernmentalism, Q11 on differentiated integration and Q12 on the EU in crisis (2 x answered). No students answered Q7 on the limits to EU's transformative power – this is not very surprising as the topic is not covered in a separate seminar by all tutors.

There is not a clear trend with a stronger emphasis on certain type of questions. Students have engaged with all questions: institutional questions, policy questions and current issues and debates.

Most exam demonstrated a good command of the core material, first class exams engage critically with the broader literature. Exams above 60 were able to present their argument in a coherent and correct fashion, but were more limited in scope and lacked wider political considerations and critical reflection. Exams above 65 had to showcase the ability of independent analysis, even if with missing aspects or few shortcomings. The five essays marked 70 and above needed to go beyond what had been covered in the lectures, go beyond textbook chapters and had to display a critical engagement with the wider academic scholarship. They showcased excellent factual knowledge about a wider variety of different aspects, a sound line of analytical argumentation, with a convincing critical reflection.

229 Advanced Paper in Theories of Justice

41 students sat this paper this year – a notable increase on previous years. The general standard was again very good, with most candidates demonstrating impressive knowledge of the literature and the ability to think critically about the issues. All scripts received overall marks of at least 60, with 28 marks within the 60-69 range and 13 of 70 or higher. The weakest candidates stuck rather closely to the contents of the lectures and/or did not adequately apply their knowledge to the specific question.

It was pleasing to see a better spread of answers this year, with every question receiving at least 4 answers. This was helped by the introduction of two new topics, on universal basic income and justice in healthcare. It was good to see take up for both of those topics, with the former being particularly popular (indeed, the question on UBI was the fourth most popular overall).

1. Is non-exploitation necessary and sufficient for justice in trade? (4 answers)

The best answers here considered various aspects of justice in trade and how non-exploitation bears upon them.

2. Do considerations of global inequality support or undermine the case for open borders? (21 answers)

The most popular question. Better answers showed good knowledge of various ways that concerns regarding global inequalities might interact with arguments for open borders. Less strong answers tacked quite closely to the lecture handout, or failed to consider both of the possibilities suggested in the question.

3. What does the urgency of responding to climate change imply for normative theorising about it? (14 answers)

Some good reflections on the implications of the urgency of climate change, both for the justifiability of specific principles (e.g. APP, PPP, BPP) and for the methodology that theorists ought to adopt (e.g. isolationism, integrationism). Weaker answers rehearsed familiar arguments without being clear about the difference that urgency makes (or does not make).

4. ‘As long as we do not make it impossible for future generations to enjoy a decent standard of living, we have fulfilled all of the requirements of distributive justice toward them.’ Discuss. (9 answers)

Some good knowledge of debates concerning intergenerational distributive justice and potential strengths and weaknesses of a sufficientarian approach, although some essays stuck rather closely to the lecture material. Although discussion of the non-identity problem was not necessary for good answers, some candidates brought it in in interesting ways, but others who discussed it failed to connect it to the specific question.

5. Can a person or a group be liable for harms that resulted from their actions when acting as they did was not known to lead to harm? (5 answers)

This question was generally well answered, with some sophisticated reflections on moral vs remedial responsibility and possibilities for assigning the latter even in the absence of the knowledge that an action would cause harm.

6. Who, if anyone, is liable for mitigating the various injustices of chattel slavery? (16 answers)

Candidates generally showed good knowledge of the literature on historic injustice, including some very recent contributions. Weaker essays struggled to connect the injustices that they argued must be mitigated to chattel slavery itself, while stronger essays mapped out these connections impressively. A few essays simply defended the candidates' preferred approach to historic injustice (e.g. BPP) without doing enough to relate the discussion to the specific question.

7. Is there a duty for an adult to repay the costs of her upbringing when she was a child? (6 answers)

Some good knowledge of debates between the society pays, parents pay, and kids pay approaches. Less strong answers offered too much of a general overview of that debate, rather than focusing on the specific question.

8. 'If it is disrespectful to intentionally enrol children into controversial worldviews then parenting well is impossible.' Discuss. (18 answers)

The second most popular question. There were some excellent discussions of reasons that parenting well might require enrolment. Less strong answers defined 'enrolment' and/or 'controversial worldviews' in ways that removed much of the puzzle by making enrolment into controversial worldviews obviously objectionable and unnecessary for good parenting.

9. 'Disability policy has primarily focused on improving access and mobility for people with physical disabilities. But this ignores, and is therefore unjust to, people with a whole range of other disabilities.' Discuss. (8 answers)

Candidates showed good knowledge of the disability literature. Some strong answers used the prompt as a way into critiquing and/or defending the social model, while others reflected well on whether different policy responses are appropriate for different kinds of disability, and indeed whether or not some disabilities receiving comparatively less attention amounted to an injustice. Less strong answers tended to view the titular statement as obviously true, and thus struggled to find an interesting line of argument.

10. Should those who fail to look after their own health have to pay more for healthcare than those who take responsibility for their own health? (4 answers)

Some good reflections on reasons that those who fail to look after their health should or should not have to pay for healthcare, although candidates perhaps showed less knowledge of the literature on luck egalitarian approaches to healthcare then one might have hoped for.

11. Is universal basic income unfair to people who have a strong preference for income over leisure? (14 answers)

Candidates showed good knowledge of the exploitation objection and various responses to it, with some demonstrating a sophisticated understanding of the debate, although some set out the objection rather too impressionistically and this was another question where some essays largely recounted material from the lecture. Less strong answers had a tendency to simply argue that UBI was fair or justified overall, without considering whether any remaining unfairness to those with a preference for income might lead us to consider alternative policies. Some essays carefully distinguished between ideal and non-ideal theory approaches to the question, while others moved between these modes of theorising rather too quickly.

12. 'It does not matter if reasons of justice do not apply to some questions within political theory, since considerations such as humanity, compassion, and care can apply instead.' Discuss. (4 answers)

Candidates took a variety of interesting approaches to this question, both in terms of identifying questions that reasons of justice might not apply to and why this might (not) matter, such as the priority of such reasons, their grounding of weighty duties, or their distinctive place within public reason.

230 Comparative Political Economy

24 students wrote the 230: Comparative Political Economy exam. As in previous years, the answers were high quality, and the typed and open-note format generally allowed for more engagement with the literature and structured responses. The answers generally used both readings and empirical evidence well. What was particularly impressive this year was the quality of the analytical arguments. The best answers took the question seriously, and worked through the underlying claims – defining core terms, interrogating the key assumptions, and setting up a clear analytic framework for answering the question. Many strong papers drew on reading and scholarship adjacent to the course. The most popular questions related to analysing the equity-efficiency tradeoff, the origins of the welfare state, globalization and the politics of inequality. The answers on the financial crisis were more mixed in quality – with some excellent answers but others less focused on the question. Some weaker responses clearly engaged with the topic, but did not direct the discussion to the question itself.

297 International Security and Conflict

This was the fifth year we provided this special paper, we had 50 finalists this year. The syllabus is extremely clear on required readings and all lectures are linked explicitly with questions and aims of the paper. Students must write at least 6 essays and we have provided systematic revisions. This year the exams' committee decided to modify our marks because our exam distribution seemed to high relative to other exams. I have concerns about this practice. This is a special paper and after several years I convened and taught it , I have to say there is a clear self-selection of extremely motivated students. Here after, the exam questions, how many students answered them and average marks (before readjustment).

1. **How recent global events have challenged "human security"?**

A strong answer needed to define "human security", then explain what the challenges were and respect to which other concepts (referring to explicit alternative scholarship). Then, using recent events such as the pandemic or transnational civil wars.
Responses: 15 Average mark: 69

2. **What is the best theoretical framework to explain inter-state war outbreak?**

A strong answer provided an overview of inter-state wars' explanations, providing Fearon as possible explanation but also challenging it with works on structural explanations or emotional /evolutionary theory. Also compared predictions of different theories and check against real cases.
Responses: 17 Average mark: 69

3. **How can regional security organization fail to promote regional stability?**

First, definitions on what is regional stability and tackling issues with the concept of stability. A strong explanation compared cases of success and failure of different regions (or over time in same region) and explained what factors played critical roles (e.g., external pressure; unresolved regional rivalries; past experience of cooperation…).
Responses: 4 Average mark: 71

4. **Are all civil wars triggered by the same processes and causes?**

Responses: 20 Average mark: 68
A strong answer challenged monocausality and provided different possible explanations and unpack historical periods and external dynamics. Comparing real examples was indeed necessary

5. **Would a global nuclear disarmament lead to a more or less stable international system?**

Strong answer first provided context about challenge of counterfactual. Then, after a review of literature, compared example of distention or escalation due to historical examples of disarment. Of course, it was necessary to provide some scope conditions of an analysis between partial and global disarmament.
Responses: 23 Average mark: 69

6. **Are domestic and international terrorisms driven by the same factors?**

A strong response provided definitions of terrorism and an overview of recent patterns. Then challenged the idea of a singular phenomenon generation processes. A discussion role of global dynamics and different types of norms and ideologies was important.
Responses: 7 Average mark: 67

7. **Compare the explanatory power of "top-down" and "bottom-up" arguments on mass atrocities.**

Using Strauss's work but also Fujii's research was essentially. A strong answer showed how the different causal directions could have synergies and how they could explain different facets of mass atrocities (e.g., repertoires, targets, intensity and duration)
Responses: 20 Average mark: 71

8. **Evaluate how a "power transition" argument can help us to understand the refugees-conflict nexus.**

This question calls for specific cases we did on Kosovo and Lebanon. A strong answer, though, also evaluated alternative explanations/limitations and showed how the power transition could be mitigated via institutional and international arrangements.
Responses: 4 Average mark: 68

9. **"Sexual violence in civil war is just explained by patriarchy". Discuss.**

A definition of patriarchy and relative literature was essential. Then, the point of not explaining variation among cases if using just a "patriarchy framework" was a second central point. The literature produced by Wood and Cohn was very helpful for this answer.
Responses: 15 Average mark:72

10. **Is transnational organized crime a security matter? Why?**

A strong answer showed how even profit oriented activities challenge the security of individuals and states. The candidate needed to show different mechanisms, also comparing to civil war literature (using Kalyvas' work). Several examples from the readings could have been used such as Colombia, Mexico and Afghanistan but also how West democracies were challenged by organised crime groups during the pandemic (as explained during the lecture).
Responses: 6 Average mark: 68

11. **Is it possible a "mutually assured cyber destruction"?**

A strong answer challenged this comparing with nuclear MAD. Then, discussing the issue of attacker identity and first-strikes. Works by Kello and Nye were helpful for this.
Responses:11 Average mark: 72

12. **Is it persuasion the best form of power UN peacekeepers can use?**

The answer needed to tackle directly with Lise Howard 2019 book and compare with other forms such us coercion, deterrence and providing goods. Of course, the candidate needed to define what means "best form of power" and for what purposes.
Responses: 8 Average mark: 71

The overall exam grades based on the agreed marks were as average 68.3 and median 68.5.

Below "65 mark": One exam got an overall 59, one a 61, two 62s, one 63 , one a 64.

Above "69 mark": we had ten 70s; four 71s; five 72s; two 73s; one 74; 0ne 75; one 76.